INVESTOR HACKS!

20 Essential Tools for Real Estate Investors

By Seth Williams

My decision to become a real estate investor has had a **major** impact on my life. It gave me the freedom to work from home, live life on my terms, and bring in some big pay checks each month.

Part of what makes this business so exciting is the fact that we *live in an exciting new world,* with amazing technology that makes it possible for you and me to do things that were unimaginable not long ago.

Real estate investing ain't what it used to be. You and I have access to some mind-blowing (and very inexpensive) resources that can make our day-to-day business operations significantly easier than it's ever been before.

Some of the biggest deals I've done over the past decade were completed from start to finish *without ever seeing the property in person.* Much of the hands-on work was outsourced to **other people** (skilled professionals who are much smarter than I am) at a cost almost anyone can afford.

It took me years to discover all incredible resources available to investors like us, so my goal is to use what I know to **shorten your learning curve**. With the tools I'm going to show you, you can do most your work (and in some cases, ALL of it) *without ever stepping foot outside your home*. When you realize what's possible, you'll be able to pursue this business in a radically different way.

If you're willing to use even ONE of the resources listed in this short guide, you'll start to see your real estate business through a whole new lens. When you start harnessing the power of these amazing tools, you'll save yourself a ton of time, energy and money.

Let's get started!

Seth Williams

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1. DataTree

If I was only allowed to use ONE item in this guide, it would be **DataTree**. This online service delivers an *insane amount of value,* because it allows me to,

- Generate targeted lists for my direct email campaigns.
- Find the owner of any property in the United States.
- Find the size, location & dimensions of any property in the United States.
- Thoroughly research any property in the United States, through detailed property profile reports.

DataTree isn't the only place you can get this information – there are plenty of other companies that offer access to similar data, but they charge hundreds (even thousands) of dollars more for the same information or make it difficult to gain access to their data.

With DataTree, you can get access to a **goldmine** of information! You can get *discounted access to this service* through the **REtipster referral page**.

Note: For an alternative to DataTree, check out PropStream. This one is very popular with real estate investors because of all the extra, built-in tools if offers. Depending on what you use it for, this one can also be a great fit for what real estate investors need every day.

2. Google Earth

Google Earth is another incredible research tool that just keeps getting better with each passing year. If you're a long-distance investor and you're trying to research properties on the other side of the world, this software is an absolute must.

In a matter of seconds, you can look up any location on earth and get a very accurate portrayal of the immediate surroundings, local amenities, the topography of the land and a lot more (and in most cases – you can see all of this *without leaving your computer*).

Google Earth gives us easy access to information that simply *wasn't available a generation ago*, and the fact that it's all available for **FREE** is even more amazing. There is **no reason** you shouldn't have this tool on your computer right now. I use it for every property I purchase.

If you aren't using Google Earth yet, what are you waiting for?? Download the desktop version today!

Hint: If you really want to level up you Google Earth experience, there's a paid software called Parlay that will add parcel lines and other useful property information throughout the U.S. You can see how it works in this video.

3. Rocket Print & Mail

If direct mail plays a big role in your business, Rocket Print & Mail is a one of the best mailing services with the best customer service I know about.

Not long ago, direct mail marketers had to spend *a lot of time and money* to do the simplest of tasks:

- Getting lists
- Printing letters
- Licking stamps
- Signing pages
- Folding papers and stuffing envelopes
- Delivering boxes of letters to the post office
- Waiting for their letters to reach each recipient

There is a lot that goes into direct mail campaign! For over a century, direct mail has been a *wildly expensive and time-consuming method of reaching people*… but even so, thousands of companies have invested billions of dollars into this marketing medium, **because it works.**

You and I are extremely lucky. We live in a time where this process has gotten much easier. Rocket Print & Mail allows you to work with a *real person* who can help you get your lists and mail pieces put together and mailed with ease. They will print, stamp, sort and send every last piece of mail directly from their facilities stationed around the United States.

You don't need to touch a single piece of paper during this process. Instead of wasting hours of your precious time, Rocket Print will handle the entire job for less than it would cost you to do it in-house anyway.

That's right! When you use this service (and sign up through the **REtipster affiliate link**), you'll get *discounted access*, so the cost of postage, paper, ink and delivery will cost significantly LESS than if you were to print, stamp and send the entire direct mail campaign on your own capacity.

It's faster. It's easier. It's cheaper.

If you haven't used a service like this yet, *what on earth are you waiting for?!*

If you have a few minutes, I've put together some step-by-step instructions on how you can place your first order. You can find it all in this blog post (scroll halfway down the page to see the video tutorial).

Note: If you're the type doesn't need all the extra customer service and you'd rather handle each order yourself, another great service is ITI Direct Mail. It works differently in some respects, but the end product is very similar and even less expensive in some cases, if you're sending out smaller batches of mail. For an alternative to Rocket Print & Mail, be sure to check this one out too!

4. Real Estate Websites

If you're a serious real estate investor (i.e. – if you have any intention of making more than pocket change from this endeavor) you really should to have at least one solid website representing your business.

Personally, I have four different websites (I call them the "four pillars") and each one plays an important role:

- **Buying Website:** This website is to generates leads from motivated sellers who want to sell their property. Visitors can submit their property information through an online form and my website will automatically generate and number and email it to them to see if they'll sell at my hypothetical offer price. When sellers respond with, "Yes", I can cherry pick the best properties and move forward with closing. This kind of website allows me to control the process of finding and closing on great deals (rather than the process controlling me), which is a beautiful thing.

- **Selling Website:** This website functions as an online showroom for the properties I'm selling. It's open to the public 24/7, so prospective buyers can browse through my listings and get the information they need to make a buying decision. When someone wants to buy, they simply notify me via phone or email, and we move forward to close the transaction. Pretty simple stuff!

- **Blog**: This one is probably the most fun. It's where I publish all the things I learn from my business endeavors (and believe me, the learning never ends). I give away 99% of this information for **free** and I sell some of the more powerful information to investors who want to use it for their businesses. Running a good blog is an ENORMOUS time investment, and it's not for everyone, but it can be very rewarding for those who take it seriously.

- **Squeeze Page**: This is a very simple, 1-page website that encourages cash buyers to join my Buyers List. By joining this list, they're usually the first group of people to hear about my new properties coming to the market (which gives them first dibs on any of my properties before anyone else knows about them).

Most real estate investors recognize that websites are helpful, but they have no idea how to create them without spending a small fortune for a professional to do it.

The good news is, websites are **VERY** easy to create these days. I've compiled some detailed instructions (with videos) on how to create each of the following. Just click on any of the links above (the bold, blue, underlined text) and you can learn all about how to make each one!

Depending on which type of website you're trying to make, there are different tools and resources that make the most sense for the job.

Currently, I'm using themes from **Pebble** for both my buying website and my selling website. Their websites are beautiful and easy to set up (they handle most of the work for you).

Pebble is actually much more than just a website solution. It can manage your entire acquisition and marketing process too, and websites are just one component of that. As a result, *Pebble isn't the cheapest option for building your first website*, so if you're on a shoestring budget, it may not be the most sensible option at first.

If you're looking for something MUCH less expensive (but, admittedly, a little less user-friendly), you can accomplish something similar with **Bluehost** and a WordPress theme like **Winning Agent Pro 2**. I used this theme for years (before I discovered Pebble) and it did a great job for me!

And lastly, if you want something less expensive than Pebble (because it's just a website, not a full marketing and tracking system) and still very easy to set up, **Carrot** is another solid contender.

They make the setup process turnkey simple and I know a lot of real estate investors who have used them for years because it's a great product! For an overview on how to get started with Carrot, be sure to check out this review.

5. Zillow

When it comes to the selling side of your business, if you're not quite ready to go through the motions of creating a selling website on your own, **don't panic**. There's still hope!

While most people know Zillow as a great place to find properties for sale in any given market, it's also a great (and FREE) way to *list your own properties for sale* on the For Sale By Owner side of their site.

Zillow is the largest online platform for buying and selling real estate in the U.S., and it's a massive source of traffic you cannot afford to ignore. Even if you do have your own selling website –you should still be listing them on Zillow too!

The real power behind Zillow is that it is **user-friendly**, it looks professional and (most important of all) it reaches a GIGANTIC audience. With a few clicks, you can promote your listings to millions of buyers online – and it won't cost you a dime!

Once you've created your account and verified your contact information, creating listings is easy! Just follow the prompts, upload any/all property pictures (and video) and publish it.

If you're not sure how to get started, check out this video for some helpful insights on what to do.

6. BombBomb

Working a real estate business over the internet has its challenges.

Imagine for a moment that you're trying to buy a property on Craigslist. After a few emails back and forth with the seller, they ask you to mail them a check for $1,000 as a deposit.

For understandable reasons, *you probably aren't going to trust a faceless name in an email with this kind of money*… and if you don't feel comfortable sending a $1,000 cashier's check to a total stranger, how can you expect others to trust YOU when you're relying on email as one of your primary methods of communication?

Establishing trust with your prospects is a big deal. When we're closing huge transactions on a regular basis, **people need to trust you**!

This is where a service like **BombBomb** comes in.

BombBomb allows you to record and send **video emails**. Your recipients will be able to *see your face and hear your voice*. It's the next best thing to sitting across the table from them! This tool can be instrumental at building trust and eliminating objections and uncertainty from the minds of your customers.

In my experience, people respond very well to video emails, and this service has made it much easier to communicate with people all over the world.

BombBomb comes with a couple different pricing options – and while none of them are "cheap", the value is undeniably huge (I've closed some major deals that never would have happened without the communication afforded by this service… so it really is worth the money if you're going to use it).

For a closer look at what BombBomb is capable of, be sure to check out this blog post for an in-depth review and you'll see what I mean – it's pretty awesome!

Note: If you're looking for a FREE way to send video emails like this, check out Loom. It's a slightly less sophisticated way to do the same thing, but it will get the job done!

7. Rocket Lawyer

When it comes to the paperwork in a real estate business, this website is a hidden gem that can add a great deal of ease and simplicity to your life.

There are dozens of websites on the internet that will sell you the basic templates to prepare your own deeds, purchase agreements, promissory notes, operating agreements and more…but Rocket Lawyer takes it one step further by asking you for the information, and then *compiling the final, completed documents for you.*

When you're working with a blank template, it's very easy to miss details and make mistakes, because you're on your own… but when you're working with **Rocket Lawyer**, it's practically impossible to miss a step, because you have to answer each question (or manually "skip" the step) in order to move on.

Here are just a few links to get started with some of the commonly used instruments in our trade:

- Purchase Agreement
- Quit Claim Deed
- Special Warranty Deed
- Contract for Deed (Land Contract)
- Deed of Trust
- Promissory Note
- LLC Operating Agreement
- Residential Lease

Rocket Lawyer can be used on a subscription basis (if you have regular need to create lots of documents) or you can pay for each document as needed.

Whatever your situations is, I think you'll find the service is well worth the cost.

8. US Legal

If you're not a huge fan of subscription services, and you'd rather do more of the hands-on work for a cheaper price, another solid option for finding state-specific document templates is **US Legal**. This is a vast online library that has just about every form and contract imaginable for the real estate trade.

If you're starting out on a shoestring budget like I did and you can't afford to pay $600/hour for an attorney to draft a simple contract for you, the forms on this website can accomplish many of the same tasks at a fraction of the price.

I've bought several of my forms from USLegal and I still use them to this day!

9. Traveling Mailbox

Traveling Mailbox is an incredibly convenient way to set up a dedicated business mailing address, so you can receive letters and packages at a physical location other than your home address.

This is a great way to keep better boundaries between your personal and business mail correspondence, and you also won't have to put your home address on all the mail you send out into the world a regular basis (this is especially helpful if you use direct mail marketing and you routinely send out thousands of mailers to complete strangers).

The best thing about Traveling Mailbox is that it allows you to receive your mail digitally. That's right! This service will scan all of your mail and allow you to read each mail piece from your desktop computer or mobile device. You can even have the original mail pieces forwarded to another address if you wish. It's pretty great! Be sure to check out this blog post for more details on how it works.

10. MapRight

If you're a real estate investor who regularly does virtual research on properties (if you're a land investor, you know how important this is), **MapRight** can be an immensely useful tool.

This web app gives you easy access to a lot of useful information about the properties you're investigating, whether the information is for you or your future buyer.

Everything from parcel boundaries wetlands, flood zones, owner information, school districts, topographical data and much more.

While the information isn't always perfect, it's an easy first-step solution that brings a lot of data into one place.

See this tutorial for an overview of how it works.

11. TenantCloud

If you're in the rental property business and you're managing your rental units yourself, you're probably familiar with all the ongoing tasks involved with that job.

- Listing properties for rent.
- Reviewing tenant applications.
- Pulling credit reports and background checks.
- Collecting monthly rent payments online.
- Processing rental applications.
- Finding the right amount to charge for rent.
- Getting tenants set up with renters insurance.

This stuff can chew up *a lot of time and energy*, but it can be a lot easier and less complicated if you're using a free, online service like **TenantCloud** to get the job done.

TenantCloud is a cloud-based software, designed to assist landlords in handling the essential, ongoing tasks of managing their rental properties. I know several landlords who use TenantCloud to fully manage their rental properties **they love this software** (which isn't something I can say about most online software and services out there).

Probably the coolest thing about this system is that, depending on which plan you sign up for, you may not have to pay anything for it! Even if you do sign up for one of the paid plans, it's still very inexpensive, considering everything it can do, which is another HUGE, compelling reason to use TenantCloud.

To get a closer look at how TenantCloud works, be sure to check out this blog post, where I explain how it works. I think you'll agree, it's pretty cool!

12. BiggerPockets

Chances are – you've heard of this website before, but if you haven't, **you need to check it out**.

BiggerPockets is an amazing resource for anyone in the business of real estate investing.

On this website, you'll find hundreds of helpful forums, blog posts, podcast episodes and more. Whatever your investing niche happens to be, you're bound to find something of value here!

13. Fiverr

This marketplace is one of the first places I go when I need to accomplish a task that I'm *completely incapable of doing on my own.*

Here are some examples of jobs I've posted on Fiverr in the past (along the corresponding prices I paid for them):

- Creating my company logos ($150 each)
- Creating videos for my real estate listings ($220)
- Creating ebook covers ($65)
- Designing ebook layouts ($100)
- Creating websites ($500 - $1,500)
- Redesigning my existing websites ($300)
- Creating the video intro for my REtipster videos ($120)
- Voiceover work for my phone system ($35)
- Audio and Video Transcription ($5)
- Legal Writing Services ($50)
- Sorting and Organizing lists for my direct mail campaigns ($50)

As you can see – it isn't terribly expensive to get *some very good help* on Fiverr. I could have easily paid 20x more for these exact same services if I had hired my local advertising agency… but that's why Fiverr is such a great resource! I can get immediate access to *thousands of experts all over the world,* and they aren't going to drain my bank account to get the job done.

If you've reached the limits of what you can accomplish on your own – don't hesitate to check out **Fiverr**.

This is a **massive pool of talent** that will help you look better, sound better and reach the next level in your business.

Also, be sure to check out this blog post for a closer look at how Fiverr works. It's pretty slick!

14. OpenPhone

If you need a better way to manage and organize your phone communication, OpenPhone is a solid platform for managing your business phone numbers, and it's what I'm using for my business right now.

They're not the only company that offers this type of service, and it's not perfect, but after working with several of the alternative options out there, OpenPhone is the best one I've experienced to date. It's easy to set up, and the features they offer have always fit my business pretty well.

OpenPhone also has a mobile app that allows you to send and receive calls and texts *from your business phone numbers,* from your mobile device (so you don't have to expose your personal phone number to all the business people you're talking with). I use this feature **all the time** and I love it!

There's a lot more I can say about it OpenPhone. If you're interested in this, check out this video to learn more about how it works!

15. Craigslist

In case you didn't already know, **Craigslist** is one of the highest-traffic websites in the world for the purpose of buying and selling real estate (and it's 100% free). I've used Craigslist to sell a TON of my properties over the years – it's a pretty big selling tool in some markets!

There are many different places you can list your properties for sale online, but of all the options I've tried, Craigslist has been the most effective advertising medium for me. If you aren't using this site to advertise your properties for sale, **you need to start now**.

Craigslist isn't without its quirks, and in some markets, it's much more effective than others, but if you can navigate through the issues, you can find a ton of value in the traffic that regularly flows through this website.

RELATED: How to Find Amazing Deals on Craigslist

16. DealCheck

Whether you're just getting started with real estate investing or you've been at it for a while, something you'll inevitably spend a fair amount of time doing is analyzing deals and crunching numbers to identify when you've got a worthwhile investment opportunity.

It's important to have access to a solid calculator that asks the right questions and prompts you to enter the right data so you can ultimately make a good investment decision.

For a lot of years, I used a SUPER complicated spreadsheet to do this. It worked, but since it was an excel file, it was a bit harder to plug in numbers and run calculations when I was on the road, away from my desktop computer.

Eventually, I learned about **DealCheck**. This is a very well-designed and easy-to-use calculator that helps real estate investors run calculations on all kinds of properties, whether it's a single family house, multi-family property, commercial space or otherwise.

Since it's all cloud-based and built as an online app, you can use it from your mobile device OR your desktop computer – they both work great! You can also save your properties and refer back to them in the future if needed.

This is a great app, and while it does have a "Pro" paid plan available for those who need to do a lot of volume and use the premium features, I think most investors will find that the Free plan is sufficient for getting started.

For a more detailed overview of how the DealCheck app works, be sure to check out this blog post, where I run the numbers on an actual deal I worked on.

17. PandaDoc

When your real estate business starts pumping out several deals each month, you'll have a lot of documents to sign on a regular basis.

- Purchase Agreements
- Letters of Intent
- Disclosures
- Assignments
- Leases
- Management Agreements
- The list goes on and on…

You could handle this the old-fashioned way, by printing, signing, scanning and emailing documents back and forth to all parties, but this is unnecessarily cumbersome because most people don't have a quick, convenient way to print, sign and scan documents on-the-fly. If you require everyone to do this, it will cause all kinds of delays, *which will ultimately cost you money.*

A much better way to handle this is with a service like PandaDoc. I've been using it for years and I LOVE how much easier it has made my life.

It's an incredibly convenient way to sign documents electronically (even from your phone) and speed up one of the slowest aspects of getting a deal closed. The service is pretty easy to use, but if you need a quick tutorial on how it works, be sure to check out this video.

18. TextExpander

A few years ago, I heard about this app that turned out to be a HUGELY helpful productivity tool in my business.

If you're anything like me – you probably have certain sentences, phrases, explanations, responses and *full-blown emails* that you find yourself typing out again, *and again*, **and again**.

I deal with this **constantly** when I'm doing things like:

- Typing out my mailing address or phone number.
- Emailing offers to people.
- Typing out long URLs I commonly refer to.
- Sending out repetitive emails that require thought, tact and finesse.
- Recalling some of the random codes I use in my website on a regular basis.

When I have to type out these things from memory, it can chew up at least a minute or two (best case scenario). When I'm writing a good email, it consumes closer to 5 – 15 minutes of my time (sometimes more), *especially when I take time to respond with an abundance of clarity*.

This is precisely what TextExpander is for.

This app allows me to generate any *pre-written string of text* (whether it's a website URL, mailing address or a *1,000 word email*) in **one second**.

Seriously, this is one of the best productivity tools I know about – I couldn't live without it! If you want to learn more about how it works, check out the video in this blog post.

19. Trello

As someone who always has a barrage of new ideas, opportunities and projects floating around in my head, it's important for me to keep my life organized. If I'm not able to visualize all the tasks on my "to do" list (which items I've finished and what still needs to get done), I would go absolutely crazy.

Luckily, I have **Trello**, which is an extremely valuable (and totally free) tool I use *every single day* to make sure details don't get missed and deadlines are met.

If I didn't have Trello to keep my life organized, I'd probably be mixing up project details and cleaning up messes all day long.

If you struggle with organization or task management on any level (whether you're flying solo or managing an entire team), Trello is definitely something you should check out.

If you want to unlock all the features of Trello, there is a paid version available, but the free version is all I've ever needed (and if your business is anything like mine, it will probably be sufficient for you too)!

20. REtipster Subscriber Toolbox

If you're a subscriber to the REtipster Blog (and if you're reading this right now, I'm assuming you are), I've set up a **TOP SECRET**, unadvertised page on the blog that *only a small handful of people know about.*

As one of my subscribers – **you are one of those people**.

I call it the Subscriber Toolbox, because it's loaded with content, video tutorials, free downloads and more (*things the rest of the world doesn't know about*). This is material that people regularly pay me money for every day, but I'm giving it to you for FREE.

This page contains some of my most valuable stuff and I don't want *just anybody* getting their hands on it. Since you've chosen to trust me with your email address, I want to repay the favor by offering you this hidden stash of gems that I think you'll find very useful.

Enjoy!
Your friend,

Seth Williams